



Office of Public Affairs
U.S. Department of Justice



Louisiana Nurse Practitioner Convicted of \$2M Medicare Fraud

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For Immediate Release

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A federal jury convicted a Louisiana nurse practitioner yesterday for her role in an over \$2 million health care fraud scheme.

According to court documents and evidence presented at trial, Shanone Chatman-Ashley, 45, of Opelousas, was a nurse practitioner and enrolled provider with Medicare. Chatman-Ashley worked as an independent contractor for companies that purportedly provided telehealth services to Medicare beneficiaries. As part of the scheme, the defendant caused the submission of false and fraudulent claims to Medicare for medically unnecessary durable medical equipment (DME). Chatman-Ashley routinely ordered knee braces, suspension sleeves, and other types of DME for patients who had not been examined by her or another medical provider. Chatman-Ashley concealed the scheme by signing documentation falsely certifying that she had consulted with the beneficiaries and personally conducted assessments of them. From 2017 to 2019, the defendant signed more than 1,000 orders for medically unnecessary DME, causing over \$2 million in fraudulent Medicare claims and over \$1 million in reimbursements. In exchange for the orders, Chatman-Ashley received kickbacks and bribes from the telehealth services companies.

"Today, a Louisiana jury convicted Shanone Chatman-Ashley of health care fraud for brazenly cheating Medicare out of its limited resources," said Matthew R. Galeotti, the Head of the Justice Department's Criminal Division. "Dishonest medical practitioners put significant strain on our health care system and reduce the quality of patient care. The Department of Justice will not tolerate medical professionals who fraudulently enrich themselves at the expense of American taxpayers. I thank the prosecutors and our law enforcement partners who worked tirelessly on this case in the pursuit of justice."

"This defendant not only defrauded the Medicare Program but went against everything the medical profession stands for, which is a promise to provide ethical and responsible patient care," said U.S. Attorney Alexander C. Van Hook for the Western District of Louisiana. "She took advantage of beneficiaries who were elderly and handicapped to order items for them that were not medically

necessary. This office is committed to continuing to work with our federal partners to stop this type of fraud in the Western District of Louisiana.”

“Illegal kickback payments undermine and corrupt the medical decision-making process,” said Special Agent in Charge Jason E. Meadows of the U.S. Department of Health and Human Services Office of Inspector General (HHS-OIG). “Both the payer and recipient of kickbacks benefit from these schemes, but it’s ultimately the taxpayers who foot the bill. HHS-OIG will continue collaborating with law enforcement and prosecutors to protect the Medicare trust fund that millions of Americans depend on.”

Chatman-Ashley was convicted of five counts of health care fraud. She is scheduled to be sentenced on July 31 and faces a maximum penalty of 10 years in prison on each count. A federal judge will determine any sentence after considering the U.S. Sentencing Guidelines and other statutory factors.

HHS-OIG investigated the case.

Trial Attorney Kelly Z. Walters of the Criminal Division’s Fraud Section and Assistant U.S. Attorney Danny Siefker for the Western District of Louisiana are prosecuting the case.

The Fraud Section leads the Criminal Division’s efforts to combat health care fraud through the Health Care Fraud Strike Force Program. Since March 2007, this program, currently comprised of 9 strike forces operating in 27 federal districts, has charged more than 5,800 defendants who collectively have billed federal health care programs and private insurers more than \$30 billion. In addition, the Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services, working in conjunction with HHS-OIG, are taking steps to hold providers accountable for their involvement in health care fraud schemes. More information can be found at www.justice.gov/criminal-fraud/health-care-fraud-unit.

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